

product and have introduced features that are specific to this demographic segment.

Q Even though CyanogenMod has managed to stay in the headlines, it is still an OS for the geeks. What is it that you offer to non-techies so that they switch from Android to CM?

There is a lot that typical users get in a CM build. Whether they are conscious of it or not, data security is the biggest factor in the global market. With the Snowden leaks, the rise of Wikileaks over the years and everything else that is going on, I think a lot of people appreciate this, even if they don't exercise their ability to protect their data. I would like to mention our security encryption that is used to 'find and wipe' devices. A lot of other companies have systems in place to do that, but since these are owned by the companies, somebody can find a device ID and ping it to locate where you are. However, our encryption mechanism is actually end-to-end. What is special about it is that we reach out to open source companies like Mozilla to create this encryption system, and to say that it is truly end-to-end unreachable. Since we open source the encryption code as well, Mozilla evaluates at the code level how the encryption model works.

Coming back to your question, even an average user is privacy-conscious. Especially now, when you hear about cases involving some China OEMs who have potentially malicious software reporting back to their servers; we want to share that none of that happens at Cyanogen. We value the fact that if you don't want to be tracked, we don't track you. As people become more aware of this aspect within India and internationally, I think this becomes a big selling point.

Q Reportedly, most of the Android apps are designed in such a way that they track the user and CM allows porting of Android apps. Do these apps affect the privacy of the users, even if they are on CyanogenMod?

Cyanogen actually allows users to stop that tracking as well. Let's take the example of Facebook, which asks you for your location. Using CM, you can actually block that request and we don't break Facebook's tracking either. What we do is give them a 'location unavailable' signal. So it shows up as if your phone was offline. As far as any such app is concerned, if it is blocked using our privacy mechanism, the company cannot track any of our users' information. So we are very meticulous about not breaking the systems of the apps, because honestly, that will get companies upset, but we do ensure that users' privacy is taken care of well.

Q How do you plan to expand the team of voluntary contributors to CM, particularly in India?

Since this is our first foray into India, our current

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contributor base is pretty modest in the country. We are working closely with the Yu community team. Yu has just recently hired two members from the Cyanogen community, to be a part of its developers' resources team within the company. But it is not just about developers. The Android community has a much wider skill set—for example, translators. I want the CM project to be a developer's live resume. Just to share one piece of information, the day Android One was launched, 17 developers ported CM on Android One devices. So, they can take those devices to someone doing an interview and say, "This is what I did, this is functional and it is on a product." Such developers can claim that they have contributed directly to the product. So, the ability to do that has a lot of value for developers and creative people.

Q Can you elaborate on the modifications that have been done to make the CyanogenMod account service smarter?

The CyanogenMod account service has evolved to be the Cyanogen account on the Yureka devices. So it is actually built on a new system. The Cyanogen account on Yureka will be our foray into planning more services inside the OS, which will be upgraded outside. India's data penetration with LTE coverage is going to explode in the next six months. So there is a lot more value in having the updates on the device with core OS functionality but these services, that are built on top, also provide value to the user.

Q Can people use CM on their devices without rooting them?

Rooting is not necessary for applying CyanogenMod. The myth of rooting has more to do with people needing a custom recovery image to flash on the official software. For instance, if you have a Samsung device, it provides the 'download mode' that allows you to download CM without rooting the device. For the platforms that allow this, rooting is completely unnecessary. Also, Yu is allowing users to do what they want and the company is providing after sales service at your doorstep. Yu is promising to repair or replace the device if you need be. So to download CM, you don't need to root your device. **END** 